THE NOBULOUS SET · GAME THREE

Automaton of Shale (AoS)

Commit everything before you know anything. Precision pays; overkill costs.

You are the Technician running Nobulous' automaton through its paces. Each Program is a row of elements that must all be funded before a single die is rolled — and Nobulous reveals what you may *not* use only after you have already committed the components the Program demands.

COMPONENTS

- 6 Experimental Technician cards
- 24 Program cards (double-sided Stable / Overheated) in three decks of 8: Routine, Specialized, Unstable
- 8 Advanced Program cards (double-sided)
- 6 Limitation cards
- 5 Element allocation mats
- **From 20 Strong:** the 17 unit dice — 4 Purple, 4 Blue, 4 Green, 4 Yellow, 1 Red
- **From 20 Strong:** the 3 stat dice — Health, Strategy and Recovery — and the Chip

SETUP

1. Choose a Technician. All six begin at **2 HP / 2 STR / 3 REC** and differ only in ability.
2. Build your Program deck — this is your difficulty. Take the stated number of Programs at random from each of the three decks, shuffle the **8** together, and return the rest to the box:

LEVEL	ROUTINE	SPECIALIZED	UNSTABLE
Easy	4	4	—
Standard	**3**	**4**	**1**
Hard	2	3	3
Nobulous	—	4	4

   Each step up trades a Routine Program for a harder one. Routine Programs ask for three elements at low Targets, Unstable ones four at high Targets, and Specialized sits between. All three decks pay the same spread of rewards, so the mix changes the workload and nothing else.
3. Shuffle the 6 Limitations into a face-down deck.
4. Shuffle the 8 Advanced Programs and set them aside for the finale.
5. Lay out the element mats. All 17 dice start available.

OBJECT OF THE GAME

Cycle your 8-card Program deck three times, then face three Advanced Programs. Finish Advanced Programming with at least 1 Health to win. **If your Health reaches 0 at any point you lose.** Health can be raised by Program Rewards but never above 6.

Cycling the deck

A **cycle** is one pass through every Program still in the deck: shuffle it, then run each Program once, in the order it comes up. Programs leave the deck permanently when they are **set aside** or when a Program Reward removes them, so later cycles are shorter. After the third cycle — or as soon as the deck is empty — go to Advanced Programming.

RUNNING A PROGRAM

This order matters more than anything else in the game.

1. **Reveal the Program.** It shows a row of elements, each with a Target, and one element ringed as the overheat marker.
2. **Reveal the Limitation.** It withholds dice from your available pool or imposes a constraint. Withheld dice cannot be used in this Program at all — not even for a required color.
3. **Commit required-color dice.** Every colored dot beside an element requires one available die of that color to be placed on that element *now*. These dice are locked there.
4. **Finish the allocation.** Distribute the rest of your available dice across the elements. An element may be left with no dice at all — it then simply fails.
5. **Execute.** Roll each element and resolve it. A hit is 1 success, a Crit is 2.
6. **Recover dice equal to your REC** at the end of every Program, before the next one is revealed.

> **REQUIRED COLORS**
>
> Red can never satisfy a required-color dot. A required die counts normally toward its element's Target — it just has to be that color, and it has to come from the dice the Limitation left you.

> **IF YOU CANNOT SUPPLY A REQUIRED COLOR**
>
> Do not execute the Program. **Lose 1 Health.** Return any withheld dice, discard the Limitation, and treat the Program as failed for Stable/Overheated progression, then move on. Running your colors dry — or letting a Shortage do it for you — has a real cost.

Requirement density

DECK	REQUIRED-COLOR DOTS PER CARD
Routine	1
Specialized	2
Unstable	1
Advanced	2

The same required colors appear on both faces of a Program card.

Limitations

- Reveal exactly **1** Limitation per Program, always right after the Program and before any required-color dice are committed.
- Yellow / Green / Blue / Purple Shortage: withhold 2 available dice of that color.
- Diversity Protocol: withhold 2 dice of different non-Red colors.
- Red Quarantine: withhold the Red die.
- Withheld dice return to your pool when the Program ends. Discard the Limitation after that Program.

Allocation threshold

Target +1 dice is the safe allocation threshold for an element, not a hard cap. You may allocate more, but every die beyond Target +1 exhausts after that element resolves regardless of the outcome.

ROLLING AND THE EXHAUSTION GRADIENT

Each element gets one Strategy roll. Additional rolls up to your STR form a **shared pool** spent anywhere in the Program — at STR 2 that is one extra roll for the whole Program. An extra roll is a **full reroll of that element's dice**: pick the element up, roll all of them again, and the new result *replaces* the old one, better or worse.

> **DICE COME BACK UNLESS YOU ARE PUNISHED**
>
> Allocating dice is not spending them. When an element resolves, its dice return to your available pool — **except** for the ones the table below burns.

RESULT	CONSEQUENCE
Exactly meet Target	**Optimal Implementation:** recover 2 exhausted dice.
Beat by exactly 1	No penalty.
Beat by 2 or more	Exhaust 1 die allocated to that element.
Fail the element	Exhaust all dice allocated to that element.
Used an extra STR roll	That element's dice exhaust regardless of outcome.

If an element uses an extra roll *and* lands exactly on Target, both apply: exhaust its dice first, then recover 2 — which may include dice you just exhausted.

> **CATASTROPHIC FAILURE**
>
> Failing exactly one element in a Program costs no Health. Failing **two or more** in the same Program is one Catastrophic Failure and costs 1 Health total.

PROGRAM REWARDS

Every Program in the Routine, Specialized and Unstable decks prints a **Program Reward**. Claim it when you complete that Program with **no failed elements at all** — one failure is enough to lose it, even though one failure costs no Health.

- **Recover 1 HP** — to a maximum of 6.
- **Recover 3 exhausted dice.**
- **Banish 1 Limitation from the game.**
- **Return 1 Overheated Program to Stable.**
- **+1 REC; remove this Program** — the bonus is permanent and the card leaves the deck.
- **+1 STR; remove this Program** — likewise.

Advanced Programs carry no reward.

STABLE, OVERHEATED, SET ASIDE

- When a Stable Program fails, flip it to **Overheated**. The ringed element's Target increases on that face.
- If an Overheated Program fails again on a later appearance, **set it aside**.
- The endgame triggers after you have cycled the Program deck three times.

ADVANCED PROGRAMMING

- Select 3 Advanced Programs. They are longer — 4 or 5 elements — and each carries 2 required-color dots resolved by the normal pre-allocation rule.
- Recover between Advanced Programs.
- **Tucking:** set-aside Programs may be tucked under the left or right edge of an Advanced Program; the exposed

edge Target adds an element. If the marked overheated element is first or last, that edge must be used; if it is internal, you choose.

- Advanced Program 1 begins Stable.
- Ending with 0–1 failed elements: the next Advanced Program begins Stable.
- Ending with 2+ failed elements: suffer Catastrophic Failure (lose 1 Health) and the next Advanced Program begins Overheated.
- Catastrophic Failure does not stop Advanced Programming unless Health reaches 0.

Complete all three with Health remaining to win AoS.

CARRYING AOS FORWARD

Only relevant if you are playing the Nobulous Research Journal (NRJ) campaign.

The **3 Advanced Programs you actually faced** are retained, preserving whether each was Stable or Overheated when faced. Three unused Advanced Programs become candidates. AoS contributes 6 cards to the Research Pool.

Stable retained cards are stronger for reducing Targets in the finale but cannot be discarded to avoid a Scenario; Overheated ones are weaker but can.